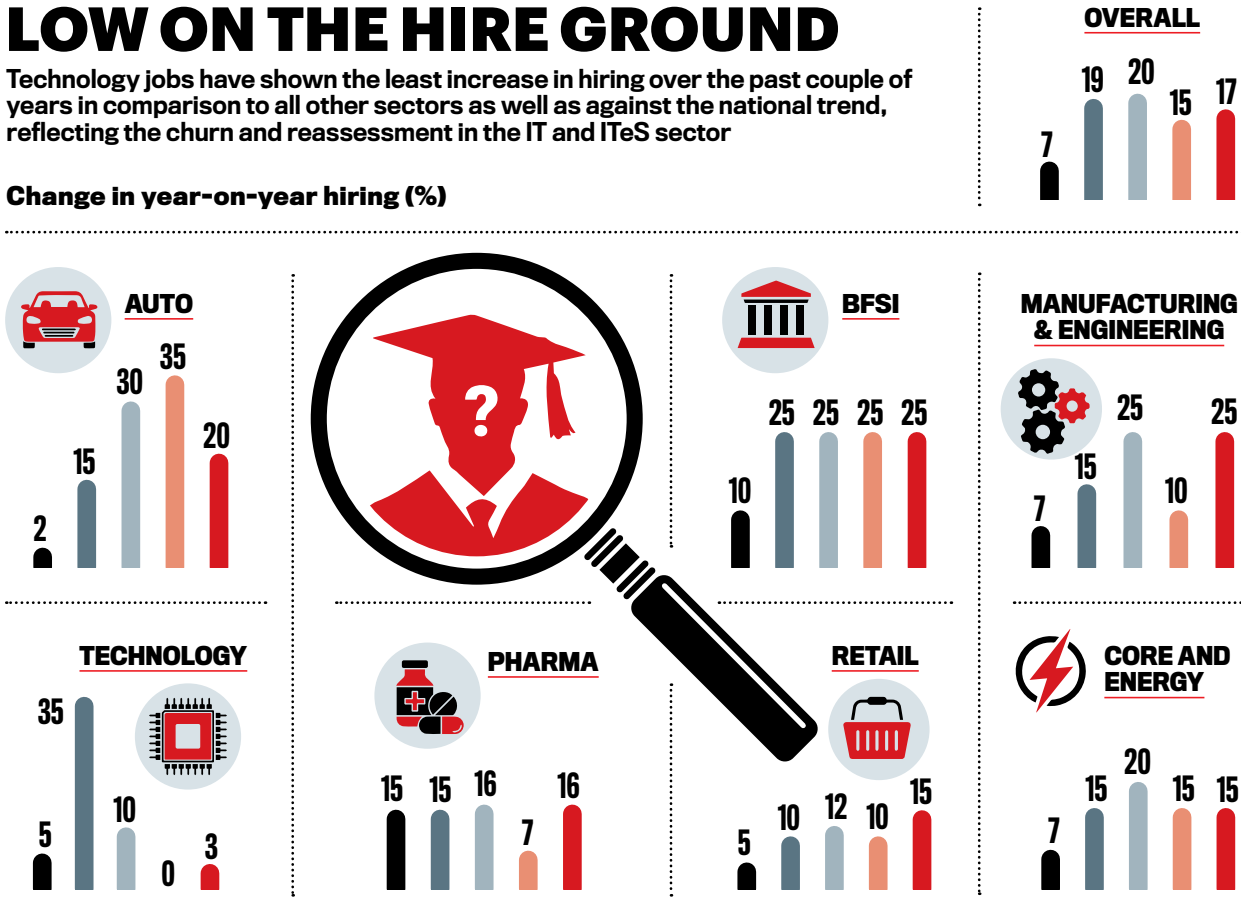
LOW ON THE HIRE GROUND

Technology jobs have shown the least increase in hiring over the past couple of years in comparison to all other sectors as well as against the national trend, reflecting the churn and reassessment in the IT and ITeS sector

Change in year-on-year hiring (%)



Source: Taggd

Note: Hiring change in percentage terms in comparison to the previous year; data from around 150 companies

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**



"The number of unplaced students has increased by 2.3 times over two years, from 3,400 in 2022 to 8,000 in 2024. In percentage terms, it has gone up from 19 per cent in FY22 to 38 per cent in FY24"

DHEERAJ SINGH
IIT Kanpur alumnus; Founder, Global IIT Alumni Support Group

ates don't take jobs in their core fields due to unattractive salaries in their specialisations," says Sankaran.

The Larger Issue

While the downturn for India's top-tier talent may eventually pass, thanks to a dynamic market and growth in sectors incentivised through PLI and domestic demand, the broader unemployment challenge for the country's 46.5 million-strong workforce remains. According to the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2022-2023, only 21 per cent of the workers in the country are engaged in regular jobs, others are either self-employed (57 per cent) or engaged in casual labour (22 per cent). "The challenge of providing meaningful livelihoods to the rest is truly massive," writes Dr Sanjiv Phansalkar, programme leader at the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust, in State of India's Livelihoods Report, 2023.

"Worse, since the disbanding of the Planning Commission, there is no data on jobs created by the private sector or on labour elasticity in the manufacturing sector," says Sunil Kumar Sinha, senior director of India Ratings & Research, a Fitch Group Company. "Even as an economist, I have to base my observations on presumptions rather than scientifically calculated estimations of the labour market."

What is the way out? According to Bhaskar Chakravorti, dean of Global Business at The Fletcher School, Tufts University, "The most significant way to absorb the workforce is through manufacturing. The problem is, India is late to the game. Most manufacturing still happens in China, Mexico and Bangladesh. We have to see if the entry of companies like Apple and Micron can attract other companies as part of the China Plus One strategy."

India has long touted its demographic dividend. It cannot afford to waste it. ■